

Case Brief: Promoting Digital Literacy for Tangible Social Media Advocacy

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Issue:

Social media has transformed into an outlet for millions of individuals, especially youth, to address fundamental issues our society is enduring. However, this form of activism has raised crucial concerns regarding the growth of performative activism that fails to result in concrete action. As Maddie Possami states in her article, “How is Performative Activism Perpetuated in Social Media,” the rise in social media “along with accessible information through social media, performative activism” has followed (Power in Place). There are clear benefits and negatives that are seen in the case of social media. This trend is exacerbated due to the inefficiencies and lack of digital literacy that leaves many youths unable to distinguish between action and performance.

Digital literacy is crucial in today’s society, yet it fails to be taught in classrooms as they mainly focus on research capabilities. Without crucial guidance, youth may misuse the internet and other various platforms. A study from the University of Connecticut found that only “4% of thirteen year-olds” are digitally literate (Schimel). To empower the next generation of changemakers, we must equip them with the proper resources to effectively utilize social media, and this is why solutions must be fabricated.

Analysis:

Solutions to the issue of youth digital illiteracy are separated into two categories: improving education revolving around social media usage and encouraging increased meaningful engagement.

Efforts to improve digital literacy have been attempted in schools with organizations such as Common Sense Media leading initiatives within schools to teach students how to navigate social media platforms with impact. These programs focus on teaching basic skills such as identifying misinformation, recognizing biases, and understanding ethicality. However, the programs within these organizations tend to focus on passive media consumption rather than material engagement in advocacy. As Elizabeth Thoman articulates in her research, “Without critical thinking skills, youth can easily fall into the trap of online activism that does not result in real-world change” (Thoman). This lack of focus on ensuring substantial advocacy leaves performative activism to grow where students engage in surface-level online actions such as hashtag campaigns like #MeToo, where the complexity of gender inequality was simplified and did not have sustained advocacy.

On a larger scale, some initiatives have attempted to address the digital literacy gap by promoting programs that educate students on how to use the internet rather than social media specifically. For instance, the “Digital Citizenship” curriculum from Common Sense Education teaches students how to create constructive online movements and “prepare students to take ownership of their digital lives” (Common Sense Education). While these programs have enhanced students’ awareness of their digital footprint, they failed to address the cruciality of

social media action. In turn, students are unable to comprehend the baseline of transforming social media into action.

Despite these efforts, the challenge remains: while students are learning how to research properly or identify false websites, they are not taught the fundamental skill of how they can take action through social media platforms. As a result, many youth take part in slacktivism (performative activism) that is fueled by the want to either become viral or convince oneself that they have accomplished something even if they haven't. Without the deeper digital literacy education with a focus on social media advocacy, this form of activism will continue to plague youth online.

Proposal:

To address the issue of low digital literacy and performative activism among youth, I propose the creation of an interactive educational platform designed to equip students with the resources necessary for authenticity online. This one-stop website will consist of two main components: an advocacy incubator to assist students in creating successful social justice campaigns and a collaborative network that connects like-minded individuals

The advocacy incubator would guide students through the essential steps of creating meaningful digital advocacy. With insights from top activists and access to resources for strategic posting, youth would be empowered to make a tangible impact in their communities and beyond. Campaigns such as #BlackLivesMatter and March for Our Lives demonstrate the power of digital platforms to drive significant change (Anderson et al.). Through this year-long program, young civic innovators would develop their skills through educational lessons and guided prompts. Participants would apply their knowledge to real-world projects, and those who demonstrate the most comprehensive understanding of digital social impact would earn the opportunity to attend a week-long trip to Washington, D.C., where they could collaborate with political leaders and representatives to propose actionable solutions.

The second key feature of this platform is the collaborative network that brings together students from across the world online. In this messaging channel, users are able to connect and develop their campaigns with others to break cultural and geographic barriers that may exist. A report from the Harvard Graduate School of Education states, "Young activists flourish when given spaces to develop their voice and collaborate with peers on issues they care about" (Ginwright). This program would ensure that the youth are engaged online properly and meaningfully. Additionally, the website would contain an AI bot that allows students to brainstorm ideas and receive real-time advice if a professional is not quick to respond.

Together, these two components would ensure that young individuals are partaking in informed and impactful activities on the internet for sustainable activism.

Community Impact:

The implementation of this platform in the Greater Houston area, my community, would greatly influence the group of youth activists present. Given the large population of individuals

with a drive and passion for change, it will be heavily utilized in the classroom or in extracurricular activities. The platform can be seamlessly integrated into numerous curricula by partnering with school districts such as Katy and Houston ISD and local youth-led non-profits. Furthermore, as the co-founder of two local non-profits with over 1,000+ supporters, Peared and Inclusive Ink, I have direct access to a community that would be extremely interested in using the application.

Teachers, community leaders, and my fellow peers can act as facilitators, helping students navigate the platforms and their various resources. Hosting both in-person and online workshops led by experienced activists will ensure that students are actively partaking in discussions. The collaborative element of this platform will encourage students from my school and also other districts to form coalitions without the boundaries of schools.

To accommodate this solution, schools and nonprofits may need to adjust their schedule to create space for civic engagement sessions and electives. Funding could be received from education grants, sponsorships, or public-private partnerships that prioritize digital learning and civic innovation.

One question that still needs to be studied is how to measure the long-term impact of this platform beyond the program period. Future research could track participants' activism outside of the program, but how this will be done is uncertain. Nevertheless, this program will allow students to learn the meaning of digital literacy and social media activism to solidify their impact in communities.

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